STORY · LESSON 7

What Did Mr. Ali Say?

A message about a test travels from student to student, and it changes on the way. Read the story, then read the exact words people said.

Report what people said | Use said and told | Pass on a message correctly

1 The story

On Wednesday, Mr. Ali was sick, so a new teacher, Ms. Nadia, came to class instead. At the end of the lesson, she gave the students a message from Mr. Ali. She said that there would be a short test on Sunday. She said that it would be about the stories from Units 1 and 2, and she told the students to bring a pencil.

After class, Adam called Omar, who had been absent that day. "Ms. Nadia said that the test was on Sunday," he said. "She told us that it was about Units 1 and 2." Then Omar called Huda. "Adam said that the test was on Sunday, about Unit 2."

Huda sent a message to the class group. "Omar says there's a test on Sunday about Unit 2, or maybe Monday?" Then someone wrote, "I heard that there was no test!" By Saturday night, nobody knew what was true. Some students said that the test had been canceled. Others said that it was on Monday.

On Sunday morning, Mr. Ali came back. Half of the students had pencils, and the other half looked very surprised. "What's wrong?" Mr. Ali asked. Sara explained what everyone had said. Mr. Ali laughed. "This is a perfect lesson," he said. "Today, there is no test. Today, we are going to learn reported speech!"

2 Questions and answers

Answer fast. Short answers are fine.

1 **Why didn't Mr. Ali come on Wednesday?**
He was sick.

2 **Who came instead?**
A new teacher, Ms. Nadia.

3 **What did she say about the test?**
She said that there would be a short test on Sunday.

4 **What did she say it would be about?**
The stories from Units 1 and 2.

What Did Mr. Ali Say? (continued)

2 Questions and answers (continued)

5 **What did she tell the students to bring?**
A pencil.

6 **Who did Adam call?**
Omar, who had been absent.

7 **What did Omar tell Huda?**
That the test was on Sunday, about Unit 2.

8 **Where did Huda send a message?**
To the class group.

9 **What did someone write?**
That there was no test.

10 **What did some students say on Saturday night?**
That the test had been canceled.

11 **How many students had pencils on Sunday?**
Half of them.

12 **What did Mr. Ali say they were going to learn?**
Reported speech!

3 Point of view

Now Sara gives the exact words that people said.

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On Wednesday, Ms. Nadia said, "There **will be** a short test on Sunday. It **is** about the stories from Units 1 and 2. **Bring** a pencil, please."

After class, Adam told Omar, "The test **is** on Sunday. It**'s** about Units 1 and 2." And Omar told Huda, "Adam says the test **is** on Sunday, about Unit 2."

Huda wrote in our group, "Omar says there's a test on Sunday about Unit 2, or maybe Monday?" Then someone wrote, "There**'s** no test!" And others wrote, "The test **has been** canceled!"

On Sunday, Mr. Ali laughed. "Today, there **is** no test. Today, we **are going to** learn reported speech!"

What Did Mr. Ali Say? (continued)

4 What did you learn?

You learned reported speech.

We use it to tell other people what someone said. The verb usually moves one step back into the past.

WHAT SHE SAID	WHAT WE REPORT
"There will be a test."	She said that there would be a test.
"The test is on Sunday."	He said that the test was on Sunday.
"The test has been canceled."	They said that the test had been canceled.
"Bring a pencil."	She told us to bring a pencil.

One step back: is → was · will → would
has been → had been, can → could

said … or told + a person
She said that… · She told us that…

Orders: told … to
She told us to bring a pencil.

QUESTIONS **What did the teacher say?** She said that the test would be on Sunday.

5 New words

instead	in the place of someone or something	**heard**	the past of hear
true	correct; real	**canceled**	stopped; it will not happen
half	one of two equal parts	**explained**	said how or why something happened